

# 46 Ehud

*The left-handed Benjamite who brought a hidden dagger and a message from God to the king of Moab.*

Ehud was the second judge of Israel. After Othniel died, Israel again did evil, and God strengthened Eglon king of Moab against them for eighteen years. When the people cried out, God raised up Ehud, a left-handed Benjamite. Sent with Israel's tribute to Eglon, he strapped a two-edged dagger to his right thigh. Alone with the king, he said, "I have a message from God unto thee," and struck him down. Then he escaped, rallied Israel, and won a victory that brought eighty years of rest.

## At a glance

|               |                                                      |
|---------------|------------------------------------------------------|
| Name          | Hebrew <i>Ehud</i> . Its meaning is uncertain        |
| Family        | Son of Gera, of the tribe of Benjamin (Judges 3:15)  |
| Known as      | "A man lefthanded" (Judges 3:15)                     |
| When          | The second judge; any BC date is rough               |
| Enemy         | Eglon king of Moab (Judges 3:12–13)                  |
| Key places    | City of palm trees, Gilgal, Seirath, fords of Jordan |
| Result        | The land had rest eighty years (Judges 3:30)         |
| New Testament | Not named                                            |

*"But when the children of Israel cried unto the LORD, the LORD raised them up a deliverer, Ehud the son of Gera, a Benjamite, a man lefthanded: and by him the children of Israel sent a present unto Eglon the king of Moab."*

Judges 3:15, KJV

# The life of Ehud

Judges gives no calendar dates. On the early chronology the judges span c. 1375–1050 BC. Ehud follows Othniel, but any date for him is rough.

|                                |                                                                                                                                                                                                                           |
|--------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Eighteen years</b>          | <div>●</div> <div><b>Moab rules Israel</b><br/>Israel does evil again. Eglon of Moab, joined by Ammon and Amalek, defeats Israel and takes the city of palm trees. <i>Judges 3:12–14</i></div>                            |
| <b>When Israel cries</b>       | <div>●</div> <div><b>Raised up</b><br/>God raises up Ehud, who is chosen to bring Israel's present to Eglon. He makes a dagger a cubit long and hides it on his right thigh. <i>Judges 3:15–18</i></div>                  |
| <b>In the summer parlour</b>   | <div>●</div> <div><b>Strikes Eglon</b><br/>Ehud returns alone from the quarries by Gilgal. Claiming a secret errand and a message from God, he kills the king and locks the doors behind him. <i>Judges 3:19–23</i></div> |
| <b>While the servants wait</b> | <div>●</div> <div><b>Escapes</b><br/>The servants think the king is resting and wait until they are ashamed. By then Ehud has passed the quarries and fled to Seirath. <i>Judges 3:24–26</i></div>                        |
| <b>At the fords of Jordan</b>  | <div>●</div> <div><b>Wins the battle</b><br/>He blows a trumpet in mount Ephraim and leads Israel down. They seize the fords and kill about ten thousand Moabites. <i>Judges 3:27–29</i></div>                            |
| <b>Eighty years</b>            | <div>●</div> <div><b>Rest</b><br/>Moab is subdued, and the land has rest for eighty years. <i>Judges 3:30</i></div>                                                                                                       |

## Group notes

# Key activities

*This is one of the most vivid and even darkly humorous stories in Scripture. Readers differ on whether Ehud's deception should be seen as approved, or simply reported. The text says God raised him up, but it does not comment on each of his methods.*

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- 1 Answered God's call.** He was the deliverer God raised up when Israel cried out. *Judges 3:15*
  - 2 Made a weapon.** He made a two-edged dagger "of a cubit length" and girded it under his clothes. *Judges 3:16*
  - 3 Delivered the tribute.** He presented Israel's gift to Eglon, "a very fat man." *Judges 3:17-18*
  - 4 Went back alone.** At the quarries by Gilgal he turned back and asked to see the king privately. *Judges 3:19*
  - 5 Struck the king.** He said, "I have a message from God unto thee," and thrust the dagger into Eglon's belly. *Judges 3:20-22*
  - 6 Rallied Israel.** He told them, "Follow after me: for the LORD hath delivered your enemies the Moabites into your hand." *Judges 3:27-28*
  - 7 Held the fords.** Israel seized the Jordan crossings, and not a Moabite escaped. *Judges 3:28-29*
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## Group notes

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# Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Ehud.

## Old Testament

|                               |                                                       |
|-------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------|
| Judges 3:12–30                | The main account                                      |
| Judges 3:31                   | Shamgar follows him, killing six hundred Philistines  |
| Judges 4:1                    | Israel again did evil "when Ehud was dead"            |
| 1 Chronicles 7:10; 8:6        | Benjamites named Ehud; unclear if either is the judge |
| Echo: 1 Samuel 9:1–2; 14:1–14 | Saul and Jonathan, later Benjamite fighters           |
| Echo: Judges 6:15             | God chooses the overlooked, like Gideon               |

## New Testament

|                          |                                              |
|--------------------------|----------------------------------------------|
| Echo: Hebrews 4:12       | God's word "sharper than any twoedged sword" |
| Echo: 1 Corinthians 1:27 | God chooses "the weak things of the world"   |

### For discussion

1. *Observe:* What details does Judges 3:15–16 give about Ehud and his weapon?
2. *Understand:* Why do you think the writer includes so many unusual, even humorous, details?
3. *Apply:* Ehud's left hand may have looked like a weakness. What trait of yours might God use in a way you did not expect?
4. *Apply:* Israel lived under Moab for eighteen years before the cry of Judges 3:15. What keeps people today from asking God for help sooner?